

Word family: **glance / glances / glanced / glancing**

Base word: glance

Forms: glances, glanced, glancing

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞) / participial adjective in some uses (部分形容詞化用法)

Your sentence:

> “...this trend may appear understandable **at first glance**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **at first glance** means **when you first look at or consider something, before examining it carefully or thinking about it in depth**.

繁體中文： **乍看之下；第一眼看來；初步看來，尚未深入分析之前**

中文翻譯：

> “...this trend may appear understandable **at first glance**.”

「.....這種趨勢乍看之下似乎可以理解。」

Here:

at first glance = 第一眼 / 初步看時所得出的印象，未必是仔細分析後的結論

1. **glance = look quickly and briefly (快速看一眼) — 瞥；迅速看一眼**

This is the central verb meaning.

Meaning: To look at someone or something very quickly, without examining them carefully.

Practice 1

> “She **glanced** at her phone.”

「她瞥了一眼手機。」

Practice 2

> “He **glanced** at the clock and stood up.”

「他**看了一眼**時鐘，然後站起來。」

Practice 3

> “I **glanced** through the window as the bus passed.”

「巴士經過時，我**迅速瞥了一眼**窗外。」

****glance = 很短暫地看某人 / 某物一下，而不是仔細觀察****

Common:

- * glance at
- * glance toward
- * glance around
- * glance back
- * glance up/down

2. ****a glance = a quick brief look (名詞) — 一瞥；一眼****

As a noun, ****glance**** means one brief act of looking.

Practice 4

> “She took a quick ****glance**** at the document.”

「她迅速**看了一眼**文件。」

Practice 5

> “One ****glance**** was enough to see the problem.”

「只要**看一眼**就能發現問題。」

****a glance = 一次非常短暫的查看****

Common:

- * quick glance
- * brief glance
- * nervous glance
- * sideways glance
- * take a glance
- * cast a glance

This is the noun counterpart of Meaning 1.

3. **at first glance = based on the first impression (固定表達) — 乍看之下；初看之下**

This is the exact construction used in your passage.

Practice 6 — Original

> “The trend may seem reasonable **at first glance**.”

「這種趨勢**乍看之下**似乎合理。」

Practice 7

> “At first **glance**, the two pictures look identical.”

「**乍看之下**，這兩張圖片看起來一模一樣。」

Practice 8

> “The plan seems simple at first **glance**, but it is actually quite complicated.”

「這個計劃**初看之下**很簡單，但其實相當複雜。」

at first glance = 還沒有仔細研究或深入思考之前，第一眼所得出的印象

The phrase often implies:

> **the first impression may later prove incomplete or wrong**

That nuance is important in your editorial passage.

4. **at a glance = immediately from a quick look (固定表達) — 一眼就；一看便知**

This is related but different from **at first glance**.

Practice 9

> “The chart lets you see the results **at a glance**.”

「這張圖表讓你**一眼就能看出**結果。」

Practice 10

> “You can tell **at a glance** which items are unavailable.”

「你**一看就能知道**哪些項目沒有供應。」

at a glance = 不需要仔細閱讀，只需快速看一下就能取得 / 理解資訊

Important contrast:

> **at first glance** = 初步印象

> **at a glance** = 快速一看就能掌握

5. **glance over / through** = look or read quickly (快速瀏覽) — 瀏覽；快速翻看

Glance can mean quickly checking written material without studying it carefully.

Practice 11

> “She **glanced over** the report before the meeting.”

「開會前，她快速**瀏覽**了一下**報告**。」

Practice 12

> “I **glanced through** the notes on the train.”

「我在火車上快速**翻看 / 瀏覽**了一下筆記。」

glance over/through something = 快速閱讀或查看內容，只抓取大概資訊

Because these are constructional/phrasal extensions, I would keep them under the basic **quick-look** meaning rather than count them separately.

6. **glance around / about** = look quickly in different directions (環顧) — 快速環顧；四處看

Practice 13

> “He **glanced around** the room.”

「他迅速**環顧**了一下**房間**。」

Practice 14

> “She **glanced around** to see whether anyone was watching.”

「她快速**四處看了一下**，看看有沒有人注意她。」

Again, this is the basic visual sense with a direction particle.

7. **glance back = look back briefly (回頭一瞥) — 回頭看一眼**

Practice 15

> “She **glanced back** before leaving.”

「她離開前**回頭看了一眼**。」

This remains under the basic quick-look sense.

8. **glance = strike something at an angle and be deflected (碰撞) — 斜擦；擦過；偏轉**

This is a genuinely different physical meaning.

****Meaning:**** To hit a surface at an angle rather than directly, and then move away or change direction.

Practice 16

> “The ball **glanced** off the post.”

「球**擦過 / 斜撞**門柱後偏開。」

Practice 17

> “The bullet **glanced** off the metal surface.”

「子彈**斜擦過**金屬表面後偏轉。」

****glance off something = 物體斜角撞到表面後沒有正面撞入，而是擦過並改變方向****

Common subjects:

* bullet
* ball
* stone
* blow

This is a major distinct sense from looking.

9. **glancing blow = indirect/oblique hit (固定搭配) — 擦撞；斜擊**

Practice 18

> “The car received only a **glancing blow**.”

「汽車只受到一次**擦撞 / 斜向撞擊**。」

Practice 19

> “The ball struck him with a **glancing blow**.”

「球只是**擦到**了他一下。」

glancing blow = 並非正面直接撞擊，而是以斜角擦過的撞擊

Here, **glancing** functions adjectivally.

This belongs to Meaning 8.

10. **glance = light briefly flash or reflect off a surface (文學 / 描寫) — 閃耀；掠過；反光**

There is also a literary/descriptive use in which light **glances** off something.

Practice 20

> “Sunlight **glanced** off the water.”

「陽光在水面上**一閃而過 / 反射閃耀**。」

Practice 21

> “Light **glanced** from the polished metal.”

「光線從拋光金屬表面**閃射出來**。」

****glance = 光線快速掠過 / 從表面反射閃現****

This is legitimate modern literary English, though much less common in ordinary conversation.

I would keep it as a ****lower-priority figurative/literary sense****, not discard it entirely.

11. ****glancing = brief / indirect / passing (形容詞化) — 短暫的 ; 順帶的 ; 擦過的****

Beyond ****glancing blow****, ****glancing**** can describe something brief or not deeply focused.

Example:

> “The report made only a glancing reference to the issue.”

「報告只****順帶 / 略略提及****這個問題。」

Here:

****glancing = brief, indirect, not thoroughly focused****

This is related metaphorically to the quick-look sense.

It is useful but relatively formal.

Related noun construction: ****exchange glances — 交換眼神****

Practice 22

> “They exchanged ****glances**** across the table.”

「他們隔着桌子****交換了一下眼神****。」

****exchange glances = 彼此快速看對方，通常帶有某種默契、反應或未說出口的意思****

This is a useful collocation rather than a separate meaning.

Useful expression: ****cast a glance — 瞥一眼****

Practice 23

> “She cast a **glance** toward the door.”

「她朝門口**瞥**了一眼。」

cast a glance = look briefly

Slightly more literary/formal than simply:

> glance at

Useful expression: **steal a glance — 偷瞄一眼**

Practice 24

> “He stole a **glance** at the answer sheet.”

「他偷偷**瞄**了一眼**答案紙**。」

steal a glance = 在不想被注意的情況下偷偷看一眼

Useful expression: **second glance / second glance needed (再看一眼)**

Practice 25

> “The picture deserves a second **glance**.”

「這張圖片值得**再仔細看一眼**。」

Especially in:

> without a second glance

> not give something a second glance

meaning:

> not look again / pay further attention

Example:

> “She walked past without a second glance.”

「她走過去，連**多看一眼**也沒有。」

Important distinction: **glance vs look**

look

is the general verb.

glance

specifically means look **briefly and quickly**.

> “I looked at the document.”

neutral.

> “I glanced at the document.”

= 我只是快速看了一眼。

A glance normally involves little sustained attention.

Important distinction: **glance vs stare**

glance

= look briefly.

stare

= look continuously and intensely.

> glance at someone

> stare at someone

They are almost opposites in duration.

Important distinction: **glance vs gaze**

gaze

means look steadily for some time, often with interest, admiration, or thought.

glance

means look for only a moment.

> gaze at the sunset

> glance at the clock

Important distinction: **glance vs glimpse**

This is one of the most important learner distinctions.

glance

focuses on the **action of looking briefly**.

> “I glanced at him.”

= 我主動瞥了他一眼。

glimpse

focuses on **briefly seeing something**, often accidentally or only partially.

> “I caught a glimpse of him.”

= 我短暫看到他一下。

So:

glance = brief look you make

glimpse = brief sight you get

Important distinction: **glance vs peek**

peek

usually means a quick look that is:

* secretive

- * playful
- * through a small opening
- * deliberately brief

glance

is neutral.

- > glance at your watch
- > peek through the curtain

Important distinction: **glance vs scan**

scan

usually involves looking over something systematically to find information.

glance

is quicker and less systematic.

- > scan a list for your name
- > glance at the list

Important distinction: **glance vs skim**

skim

typically applies to reading.

It means read quickly to get the main ideas.

glance

can apply to almost anything visual and may be even briefer.

- > skim an article
- > glance at an article

The second suggests less reading.

Important distinction: ****at first glance vs at a glance****

This deserves special emphasis.

****at first glance****

= based on your first impression

> “At first glance, the plan looks sensible.”

「乍看之下，計劃似乎合理。」

There may be more complexity later.

****at a glance****

= quickly and immediately from looking

> “The dashboard shows performance at a glance.”

「儀表板讓人一眼便掌握表現。」

Different functions.

Grammar note: ****glance at****

The usual preposition for the object you look at is:

> ****glance at someone/something****

Examples:

> glance at the clock

> glance at the screen

> glance at someone

Not normally:

> glance something ❌

The visual verb is usually intransitive.

Grammar note: **glance toward/across/back/up/down**

Direction can follow without **at**:

- > glance toward the door
- > glance across the room
- > glance back
- > glance down

These describe where the quick look moves.

Countability note

The noun **glance** is countable:

- > a glance
- > two glances
- > several glances

Common patterns:

- * take a glance
- * cast a glance
- * exchange glances
- * one glance
- * at first glance

Family-extension note

The practical morphological family is small:

- * **glance**
- * **glances**
- * **glanced**
- * **glancing**

Most of the richness comes from constructions rather than derivatives:

- * glance at
- * glance over/through
- * glance around

- * glance back
- * at a glance
- * at first glance
- * exchange glances
- * glancing blow

A full second-pass audit also reveals the separate **physical deflection** branch and the lower-priority literary **light glancing off a surface** use.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
glance — look briefly	很短暫地看某人 / 某物一下，而不是仔細觀察
a glance	一次短暫快速的查看；一瞥
at first glance	第一眼 / 初步看來，尚未深入分析之前
at a glance	只需快速看一下便能立即掌握資訊
glance over/through	快速瀏覽文字、文件或內容
glance off — physical	物體以斜角擦撞表面後偏轉
glancing blow	斜向擦過而不是正面擊中的撞擊
glance — light	光線在表面短暫閃現 / 反射；較文學
glancing — figurative	短暫、順帶、不深入的；較正式
exchange glances	彼此快速交換眼神

For your original sentence

> “...this **trend may appear understandable at first glance**.”

The exact meaning is:

at first glance = 如果只作初步、表面的觀察，而還沒有深入考慮所有後果

So:

> **understandable at first glance**

= **乍看之下似乎可以理解**

The writer deliberately uses this phrase to signal:

> **once we examine the issue more carefully, the initial impression may no longer hold.**

For your database, I would count **3 genuinely useful core meanings** for **glance**:

- look briefly / a brief look**
- strike something at an angle and be deflected**

3. **light flash/reflect briefly off a surface** — lower-priority literary sense

I would keep **at first glance, at a glance, glance over/through, exchange glances, glancing blow** as important constructions/extensions rather than artificially inflate the core count.